zhol · TEF Ignition 2026 · Workshop 2

Early signals

What the first ten answers to our one-minute survey say about disruptions in freight, by road, rail and sea

13 November 2026 · Survey open since 9 November · A small sample, read as direction, not proof



The 2-minute pitch

The problem

Hi, we’re zhol. Europe moves its goods by road, rail and sea, and every country stops them by its own rules. On a typical week 14 to 17 countries ban trucks alone, each with its own hours and holidays; rail and port strikes are announced days ahead, ferries and blockades stop at short notice. A traffic office plans ahead and finds out at five in the morning, from a driver in a three-hour queue or a terminal that did not open. People who know the field put one stopped shipment at €300 to €1,000.

What zhol does, unlike a map

Google Maps shows a driver the traffic right now. zhol estimates which shipments, by road, rail or sea, will be hit and what it costs, warns the office in advance and updates it in real time. The office sends its loads as Excel or a photo. AI agents read the official bans of seven countries so far, the dosing calendars, strike notices and over 400 news articles a day, and a person checks every alert. Offices also share what their drivers see, news that is never online, and get everyone else’s in return. No map and no TMS has that network.

Who pays, and how big

The owner pays per vehicle, €12 a month. We asked eight people who know the field, from shippers, rail and ports; they put a fair price at €5 to €10, so our first ten offices pay €8. Europe has about 78,000 traffic offices, and we do not need all of them: if one in ten pays, that is €24 million a year; one in five, €48 million; three in ten, €72 million; half of them, €120 million. We start in Northern Italy, a day from Milan, with 2,350 offices, and follow their lanes into Austria, Germany, Switzerland and France.

About 290 words, two minutes at a calm pace. Spoken, no slides at the table.

Why Europe

Every European country stops freight by its own rules.

One trip from Milan to Munich crosses three rulebooks, by road or by rail. The information exists, but it is scattered, in many languages, and it changes overnight.

Own bans. On a typical week 14 to 17 countries ban trucks, each with its own hours and weight limits.

Strikes and blockades. On the road, on the railways, in ports and on ferries, announced days ahead or at short notice; eight days of blockades in southern Italy cost over €400M.

Own holidays. Italy, France, Switzerland, Austria and Germany stop trucks on different days.

Office hours. Offices check in office hours. Disruptions start at night and on holidays.

We start in Northern Italy, a day from Milan, and follow our offices' lanes into Austria, Germany, Switzerland and France.

Bans: weekly European truck-ban tracker, 2026. Road congestion alone costs the EU about €100bn a year, about 1% of GDP (European Commission); context, not our market.

How big

We do not need every office. One in ten is €24 million a year.

Europe
78,000
traffic offices in the EU, EEA and Switzerland

Italy
6,050
offices with weekly lanes abroad

We start here
2,350
offices in Northern Italy, 6 to 100 vehicles

Our plan, year 3
250
paying offices, about €0.8M a year

If this share of offices pays	10%	20%	30%	50%
Northern Italy, where we start	€0.7M	€1.4M	€2.2M	€3.6M
Italy	€1.9M	€3.7M	€5.6M	€9.3M
Europe	**€24M**	**€48M**	**€72M**	**€120M**

A year, at about €3,080 an office: 21 vehicles at €12 a month. Offices from Eurostat, KU Leuven for the ETF, CLECAT and Italy’s haulier register; details in docs/01. The shares are scenarios, not our plan.

Who answered: ten people in three days

2

traffic offices

Neither yet in our target segment of 6 to 100 vehicles with weekly lanes abroad

8

people who know the field

5 teach or research logistics, 3 work around it in forwarding, an association or consultancy

The part of transport they know

Shippers 3 · rail and intermodal 2 · ports 1 · several 2 · road haulage 0

How they reached the survey

Professors’ letters 7 · direct link 2 · a letter to a company 1

Language

Italian 6 · English 4

Also asked in person. The team ran the same questions in person with more people in the field, and their answers were similar. Those answers are not entered here yet, so they are not counted in these numbers.

Answers since 9 Nov, 17:00 UTC; the team’s own test runs left out. Anonymous, reported only in aggregate.

Four numbers from the eight who know the field

Time an office spends checking each day

4 of 7

say 20 minutes or more, 3 of them over 40. Our bar for offices is 5 of 8.

Shipments abroad changed per 100 in a month

8 of 8

say 2 or more, 3 say over 10. Our bar is 5 of 8.

Cost to the carrier of a stopped shipment

€300–1,000

the median of the 6 who gave a figure; 2 did not know. Our bar is €300.

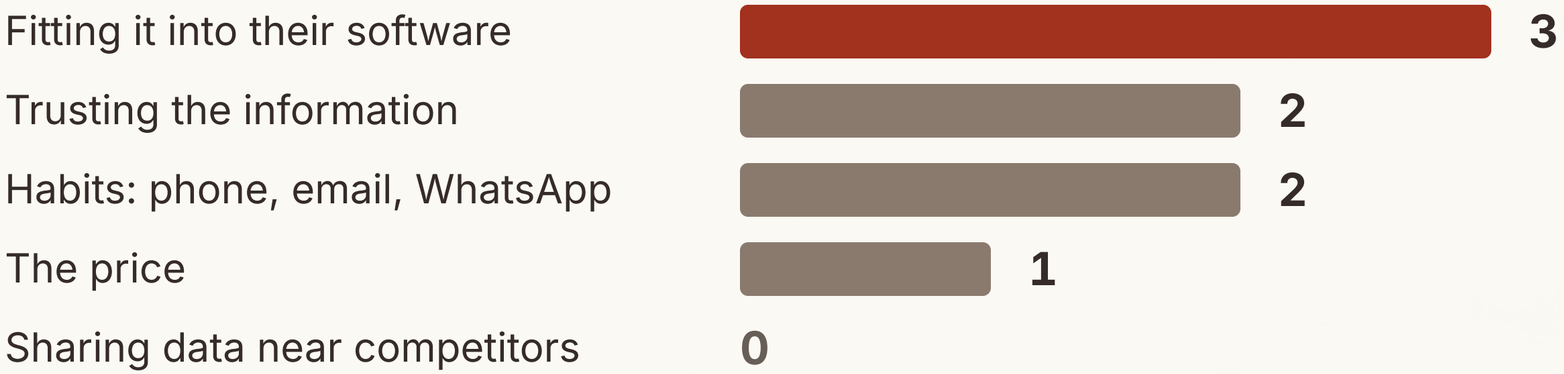
A fair price per vehicle a month

€5–10

the median of the 6 who gave a figure. Our founding price is €8.

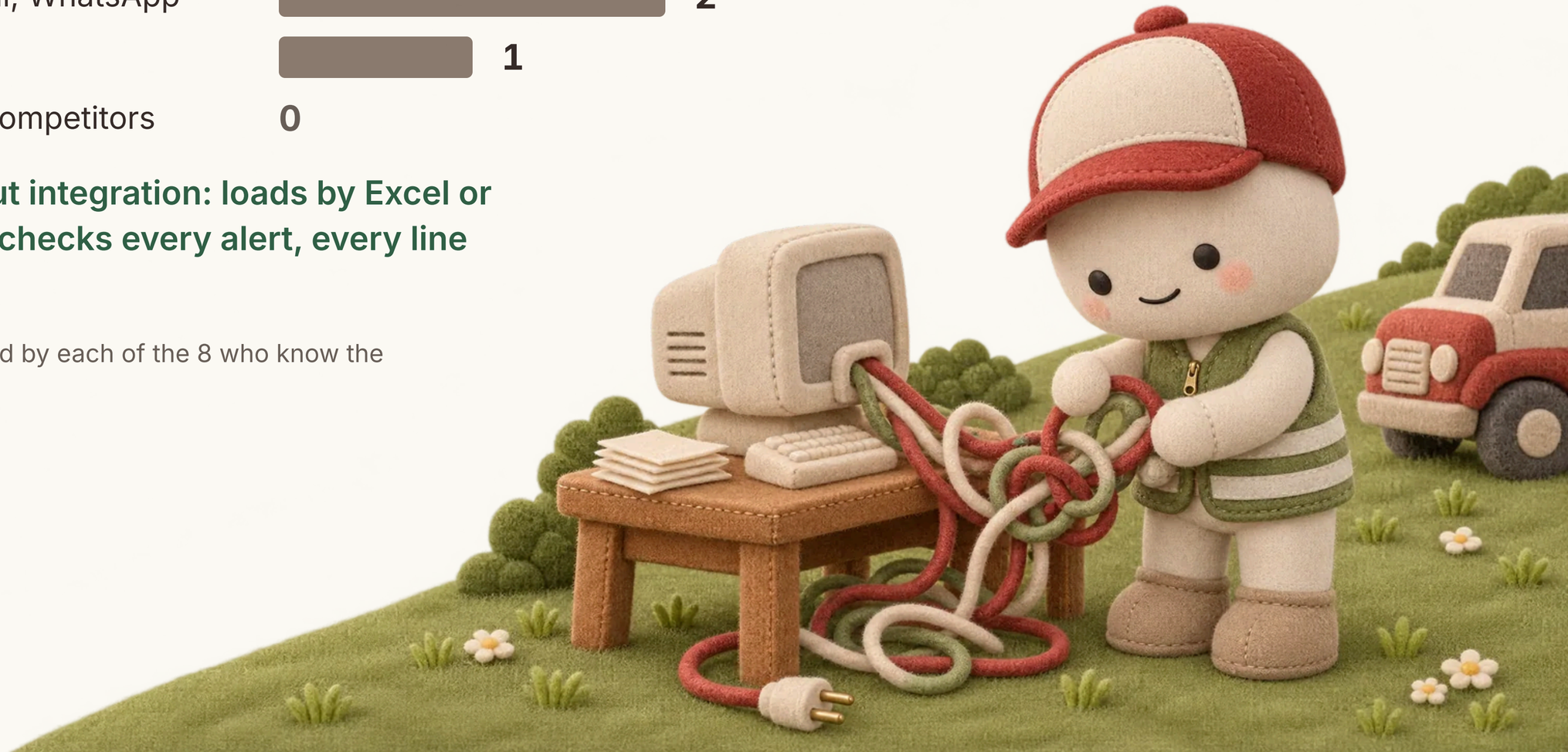
Answered from experience, not about their own desk. The 2 offices are too few to read and are left out here. Bars fixed before collection, docs/10.

What would hold an office back



So we start without integration: loads by Excel or a photo, a person checks every alert, every line cites its source.

The main obstacle named by each of the 8 who know the field.



Would offices share what their drivers see, if it stays anonymous?

6 of 8

say most or some offices would. Of the eight, 3 said most, 3 said some, 2 said few.

That is the base of the shared watch. A driver stuck at the border tells the radar, and every office on that road knows before its loads leave.

After answering, 4 asked to receive the results and 1 asked for a place in the shared network.



One office with 20 vehicles, projected from the answers

Conservative

2 changed per 100 trips, €300 each, the lowest the experts gave

4 shipments changed a month

€600

a month avoidable, 2.5 times the €240 subscription

Our model

4 per 100, 3 hours of waiting at €100 an hour, from docs/03

8 shipments hit a month

€1,200

a month avoidable, 5 times the subscription

The experts' median

5.5 changed per 100 trips, €650 each

11 shipments changed a month

€3,575

a month avoidable, about 15 times the subscription

20 vehicles, half on lanes abroad, 20 one-way trips each: 200 legs a month. An early warning avoids half of the cost. A projection, not yet measured at an office.

Across the 2,350 offices in our segment

Cost an early warning could avoid

€17–101M

a year, from the conservative case to the experts' median; our own model gives €34M

What the segment would pay us

€4.5–6.8M

a year at €8 to €12 per vehicle a month, 20 vehicles per office

Price check

The experts' median fair price is €5 to €10 per vehicle a month. Our €8 founding price sits inside it; the €12 standard price sits above it, so the interviews test it.

Offices with 6 to 100 vehicles and weekly lanes abroad in northern Italy, between 1,170 and 3,500 (docs/09). Every input except the experts' answers is our assumption.

A second segment to test: large operators on our corridors

Company	Where	Published scale
Arcese	Basiano, Milan	3,500+ people, 70 sites
DHL Freight Italy	Pozzuolo, Milan	180 terminals, 40 countries
Raben Italy	Cornaredo, Milan	300 people, 13 branches
GTS	Bari	Rail-road network
Torello	Montoro, Avellino	2,770+ people, 40 sites
Nicolosi Trasporti	Catania	110,000 m² storage
FERCAM	Bolzano	1,460 people, 23 countries
GRUBER Logistics	Ora, South Tyrol	750 trucks
LKW WALTER	Kufstein branch	1.7m+ full loads a year
Gebrüder Weiss	Lauterach, Austria	8,600 people, 180 sites

What changes with them

Same problem, a different buyer.

They buy per desk and want the alerts inside their own system.

One desk. One team on one lane, not the whole group.

Budget. Per desk, lane or flow, not per vehicle.

Integration first. Alerts arrive in their own TMS.

Separate segment. It does not add to the 2,350 offices.

Company facts from their official websites, checked by the team on 12 November 2026. None of these companies has answered our survey or spoken to us yet.

A 200-vehicle pilot: only new, useful alerts count

200 vehicles × half abroad × 20 one-way legs = **2,000 legs a month**

2,000 × 5% affected × €650 per changed load = **€65,000 of disruption cost a month**

New, useful share of affected loads	Avoided a month	After the €1,600 subscription	Benefit to price
5%	€1,625	€25	1.0 times
20%	€6,500	€4,900	4.1 times
35%	€11,375	€9,775	7.1 times

The deciding number is how many alerts the office did not already know. The pilot logs exactly that: the first notice, the decision it changed, the cost avoided.

Assumptions: 5% affected and €650 a load, near the experts' medians; half of the cost avoidable; €8 a vehicle. At €12 the subscription is €2,400 and the 5% case loses money. Integration and onboarding not counted.

Why zhol, and not what they already use

What they use today	What it gives them	What it misses
Google Maps, Waze	Live traffic for a driver, right now	Tomorrow’s shipments, bans, rail and port strikes ahead
Ban apps, the TIMOCOM portal	The calendar of bans	Nothing per load, nothing unplanned
TMS: Zucchetti, Dylog, Qargo	Tomorrow’s loads, in their system	No outside events at all
Telematics: Webfleet, Samsara	Where each vehicle is right now	What happens on the road tomorrow
Drivers’ WhatsApp groups, calls	Fast, free news from the road	Office hours, unchecked, no options
zhol	**Each shipment’s risk and cost, in advance and in real time**	**Planned and unplanned, checked by a person, with options**

History no one else has

A verified record of every disruption and what it did to real loads.

Give news, get news

An office that shares what its drivers see gets what every other office’s drivers see. None of it is online.

Their associations, their price

Sold through hauliers’ associations, at €12 a vehicle, under a telematics seat at €10–35.

An AI-first TMS such as Qargo is the most likely to add this; our answer is the history and the shared watch, which a single TMS cannot build alone. Sources in docs/02.

How the MVP works, and how we reach offices

Four steps, from the estimate to the update

Once · the office sends its planned shipments
Excel, CSV or a photo, under two minutes. No software to install.

Estimate · risk and cost for each shipment
Official bans of 7 countries, the Tyrol dosing calendar, the radar of 445 articles a day from 30 of 31 sources. In the MVP, checks run at 17:30 and 20:00.

Before sending · a person checks each event
Target 90 seconds an event, 15 minutes a day per corridor set, about €1,000 a month.

In advance, then updated · WhatsApp only when hit
As soon as the event is known: the shipment, what happens, the options with their cost, the source. A new message when it changes.

Go-to-market

We reach owners through people they already trust.

Then a free pilot proves the savings before anyone pays.

Founder-led. In Italian, to owners in the north: 200 named offices, 92 already listed.

Associations. FAI Conftrasporto, CNA Fita, Confartigianato Trasporti, with a member webinar and 15% off.

Introductions. Bocconi professors and the TEF network for the first pilots.

Bulletin. A free weekly Brenner and Alpine bulletin on WhatsApp.

Later. TMS and telematics partners, wholesale at €3–5 a vehicle.

First 10 weeks: 200 contacts, 40 conversations, 12 interviews, 4 pilots, 2 paying offices.

Cost to serve €1,230 a month at 10 offices (52% gross margin), €1,985 at 100 (92%). Human review is most of it. docs/03, docs/05.

Testing with customers: what counts as success

The question	How we measure it	Success if
Time saved	Minutes a day spent checking, timed on 3 pilot days	20 min or more in 5 of 8 offices
Money saved	4-week pilot ledger: only alerts the dispatcher confirms, events outside the calendar	€500 or more, and twice the price
Who signs, how much	Interview: who approves, the monthly amount they sign alone	Owner in 6 of 8, €200 a month or more
Price and package	Four prices per vehicle; alerts, alerts with options, or per shipment	€8 a vehicle acceptable; one package for 5 of 8
Feasibility	Official sources, review time, correct alerts, missed problems	70% official, 90 s, 80% correct, at most 1 missed
Conversion	Pilots that sign the founding offer	2 of 4

Fixed before we collect anything. The monthly statement leads with the benefit offices name most.

Thresholds from docs/10. Financial plan in docs/13: base case break-even May 2029, €155k to raise; rebuilt after the pilots.

Next: hear it from the offices themselves

1 · Introductions

Bocconi professors introduce us to hauliers with lanes over the Alps. Cold letters got no company reply yet.

2 · Interviews

Eight conversations with traffic offices, against the same bars.

3 · Pilots

Two offices, real restriction days, one WhatsApp message per hit load.

The bars were fixed before we collected anything. If the offices miss them, we narrow the segment or move it.

zhol.live · the survey stays open at zhol.live/survey, in five languages

